

Jacco Tholens

Regional Delivery Director – East Asia & Pacific
Industrial Automation
Schneider Electric, Australia

10.5.2026

The Director
United States Citizenship and Immigration Services
Department of Homeland Security
United States of America

Subject: Letter in Support of Dr. Sandhya Haridas's Petition for Classification as an Alien of Extraordinary Ability under EB-1A

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am writing to provide direct testimony regarding the critical role that Dr. Haridas performs within Schneider Electric, a multinational enterprise with a distinguished reputation in the field of energy management and industrial automation. I write from inside the organization, with first-hand visibility into the scope of her responsibilities, the scale of her business, and the measurable consequences of her leadership. In twenty-five plus years in this industry I have written letters of this kind, but I write this one with particular care because the work I observed deserves it.

My name is Jacco THOLENS, I serve as Regional Delivery Director for East Asia & Pacific – Industrial Automation at Schneider Electric in Australia. Overall, 25 years of Industrial experiences working for Europe, India, East Asia and Pacific. I am with Schneider Electric Australia for 7 years with extensive large project implementation and on-site commissioning. Last 10 years active in Leadership and Management roles, specialising in operational management, standardisation and organisation optimisation. In my most recent role, I am responsible for the execution teams across East Asia and Pacific at Schneider Electric, managing a 75M Euro portfolio, and ~250 people. Dr. Haridas's was directly reporting to me as Director India-Operations and Delivery while I was responsible for APAC region in 2023, 2024.

About Schneider Electric

Schneider Electric is one of the world's largest energy management and industrial automation companies. The company has been a member of the Fortune Global 500 for twenty-three consecutive years and ranks among the top ten in the global electronics industry. In January 2025, Corporate Knights named Schneider Electric the World's Most Sustainable Corporation, making it the only company in the 21 year history of the Global 100 ranking to take the top position twice. TIME magazine, in collaboration

with Statista, also named Schneider Electric the World's Most Sustainable Company in both 2024 and 2025. Gartner has ranked Schneider Electric number one in its Top 25 Supply Chain for three consecutive years through 2025.

Dr. Haridas's Position and the Structural Importance of Her Role

Dr. Haridas serves as Business Unit Head and Delivery Director for Industrial Automation in India. Industrial Automation is one of Schneider Electric's core technology lines and a primary driver of revenue, customer retention, and digital transformation outcomes for global customers. Within this business, the India unit functions as both a profit-and-loss-owning regional business and a global delivery hub serving customers across the Middle East, Africa, Southeast Asia, and selected European geographies.

The role itself is critical to Schneider Electric for three structural reasons.

First, the position carries unified ownership over commercial outcomes, engineering execution, regulatory compliance for safety systems, and senior customer relationship management for more than 250 customers and over 300 active mission-critical projects at any given time. There is no parallel role at this scale within Schneider Electric's Indian operations, and the consolidation of these accountabilities into a single role reflects the strategic weight Schneider Electric assigns to it.

Second, the unit is the principal scaling lever for Schneider Electric's industrial automation strategy across the broader Asian region. Decisions taken at the head of business unit level determine engineering capacity, product mix, customer prioritization, and the deployment cadence of advanced offerings of digital transformation such as cyber security, artificial intelligence applied to engineering, operational technology and information technology convergence, and digital twin platforms. These are not delegated decisions. They are made by the role Dr. Haridas occupies.

Third, the unit is responsible for safety-critical systems in environments where engineering failure carries severe consequences. Refineries, supercritical power plants, and chemical processing facilities operated by Schneider Electric's customers across the region depend on the Distributed Control Systems, Programmable Logic Controllers, and Safety Instrumented Systems engineered, integrated, and commissioned under Dr. Haridas's leadership. The role is critical not only to Schneider Electric's commercial outcomes but to the operational safety of large industrial assets.

Quantified Contribution During the Period of Direct Observation –

The following statements reflect data I personally reviewed in internal business performance reviews and project audits during my tenure. Source documents on each figure can be produced on request and are referenced inline where relevant.

She leads a business portfolio that exceeds 97.2 million United States dollars in annual revenue and a workforce of more than 350 engineering and delivery professionals. Within twelve months following the integration of an acquired business into her unit, the organization scaled approximately twofold in revenue and headcount under her direction, without revenue disruption, customer attrition, or safety incident. Customer relationships managed personally by Dr. Haridas account for approximately 40% of the business unit's revenue, a figure tracked in Schneider Electric's internal customer revenue attribution reporting monthly customer satisfaction and quality report. She delivered double-digit annual sales growth, year-over-year improvement in gross margin, and an increase in customer satisfaction scores from 55 percent to 86 percent, a thirty-one-percentage-point movement that placed India among the top-performing Industrial Automation regions globally in Schneider Electric's internal ranking from monthly customer satisfaction and quality department. Beyond the individual metrics, what I observed was, a leader who elevated the entire delivery organization's performance with her own discipline and customer ownership became the operating standard.

Scarcity of Her Skill Profile and the Rarity of Her Expertise

In my twenty five years across industrial automation, sustainability, and digital transformation, I have rarely encountered a leader whose skill profile combines, at the level Dr. Haridas demonstrates, doctoral-level research expertise in artificial intelligence with operational profit-and-loss ownership over a large industrial automation business, deep engineering authority over safety-instrumented systems for refineries and supercritical plants, and the ability to architect and execute operational technology and information technology convergence at scale. Each of these competencies is scarce on its own. Their combination in a single leader is, by my direct observation, in hiring and leadership succession planning across the region, very rare.

This is not a subjective observation. It is consistent with industry-recognized labor market data.

The convergence of operational technology and information technology has been identified across the industrial sector as one of the most acute talent shortages of the current decade. Independent industry analysis concludes that organizations struggle to fill operational technology roles and information technology roles separately, and that finding leaders capable of integrating the two domains is significantly harder still. The 2026 SANS cybersecurity workforce report identifies skills gaps, rather than headcount shortages, as the industry's most acute workforce challenge, with the gap most pronounced in critical infrastructure and operational technology environments. The World Economic Forum has reported a global shortage of approximately five million skilled cybersecurity professionals, with the cyber skills gap widening by approximately eight percent in 2024 and two-thirds of surveyed organizations reporting moderate-to-critical talent shortages.

Schneider Electric has publicly acknowledged this scarcity. In a cybersecurity workforce article published in May 2025 on the company's official corporate blog, Schneider Electric noted that operational technology cybersecurity skills are even more scarce than traditional information technology

cybersecurity skills, and that the talent and skills challenge for companies operating in both domains is more complex than the broader cybersecurity workforce gap. This is the company's own published position. Dr. Haridas operates squarely in this scarce intersection, and her work has been a direct response to it inside our organization.

Layered on top of the operational technology and information technology convergence scarcity is the additional rarity of doctoral-level expertise in responsible artificial intelligence applied to industrial systems. Industrial artificial intelligence research at the doctoral level is itself a small specialty. The number of practitioners who hold a doctorate in this field and simultaneously own commercial responsibility for a large industrial automation business unit is, in my professional knowledge of the field, very small. I cannot name a comparable peer in Schneider Electric's India operations, and I am aware of only a handful in the broader Asian industrial automation market.

Dr. Haridas's profile combines four scarce competencies: doctoral research in responsible artificial intelligence, profit-and-loss leadership of an industrial automation business at scale, deep engineering authority in safety-instrumented systems, and the ability to lead operational technology and information technology convergence in regulated industrial environments. Each of these is in short supply individually. Their convergence in a single leader is, in my direct experience of the labor market, a rare event. The role she occupies at Schneider Electric does not have a deep substitution pool. It would not be filled, in a counterfactual scenario, by a candidate of comparable capability within any reasonable recruitment timeline.

Comparative Standing Among Peers I Have Observed

To place Dr. Haridas's performance in comparative terms, the following anchors are the most useful, drawn from Schneider Electric's internal benchmarking and from my own twenty-five years of observation in the industry.

Within Schneider Electric's Industrial Automation organization globally, the India business unit under Dr. Haridas's leadership achieved a customer satisfaction score that placed it among the highest-performing regions during my period of observation. Schneider Electric runs internal regional rankings on customer satisfaction for this business; the India unit moved from the lower tier into the top tier under her leadership, a positional shift that the regional leadership of other geographies did not match in the same period.

On adoption of artificial intelligence in industrial engineering work, Schneider Electric has piloted such initiatives in multiple regions. The methodology Dr. Haridas developed and deployed produced engineering efficiency improvements of over sixty percent and effort reductions of approximately fifty percent at the India unit, figures that exceed the gains reported from comparable initiatives in our other regions during the same period. Elements of her approach have since been transferred to other geographies, which is itself a comparative datum: her work was the reference, not the recipient.

Across the senior business unit leaders, I have personally observed in industrial automation in my career, including those educated at premier institutions, operating at peer multinational firms, Dr. Haridas occupies a position in the top tier. In my professional judgment, anchored in the cohort of leaders I have actually managed, partnered with, and reviewed in succession-planning conversations, she ranks within the top one to two percent of business unit leaders I have encountered. I do not make this kind of statement lightly, and I have not made it about more than a small number of leaders in my career.

Differentiation: What Would Not Have Occurred Under a Different Leader

The proper test of a critical role is whether the outcomes attributed to it would have occurred under a different leader of average competence. In Dr. Haridas's case, my honest answer is that they would not have. Below examples are illustrative of the same.

One of her most pertinent contributions has been the innovation driven culture by leading example and passionately being involved from strategic planning, effective planning and ensuring meaningful outcomes. Two significant events are Digi-innovation – Hackfest or Hackathon and Sustainability Campaign for India -Organization. Hackathon that involved principally Delivery function, was a very successful event with maximum 95% participation, presenting 80 ideas which went 3 levels of assessment to top 35+ ideas on this Digi-Innovation platform. Her collaborative approach driving her organization towards Digital Transformation has been remarkable. Dr. Haridas core competency of Digitalization empowered India Delivery Organization a different lens, the creation of Digital and Cyber COE (Center of Excellence) as a strategic business initiative. This initiative has consistently delivered triple-digit growth in order booking and revenue, demonstrating her ability to identify high-potential growth areas and execute them successfully. She further strengthened this strategy by conducting digital workshops with customers, positioning the organization to enter and expand in high-margin digital and cyber businesses. She actively encouraged and invested in enabling team members to participate in seminars and forums related to AI, Cybersecurity, and Digitization, reinforcing a culture of continuous learning and future readiness.

She led a strategic digital transformation and cybersecurity capability-building program that resulted in the organization successfully obtaining empanelment from the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team, the Government of India's apex cybersecurity authority under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology. This recognition is awarded only to elite organizations that demonstrate advanced technical expertise and pass a highly selective, multi-phase evaluation process, positioning the organization among a limited group of nationally trusted security auditing firms authorized to assess critical infrastructure and government systems. Her team under able leadership are few among qualified to audit Information Technology assets of government organizations as an Operational Technology players, which kills competitors in Information Technology space.

She has been a strong proponent of digital transformation. She led multiple digital initiatives aimed at improving productivity in business operations, ensuring that technology was leveraged as a value enabler rather than a support function. Initiatives such as “Digital Friday” were introduced to create awareness and readiness around digitization and Industry 4.0 and 5.0 trends. These initiatives significantly enhanced digital literacy within the team, preparing the organization for future technological shifts.

Sustainability— Made a lasting organizational impact by advancing Schneider Electric’s core sustainability value through the design and execution of structured engagement initiatives that drove employee participation and innovation. Launched competitive idea-generation programs that encouraged cross-functional teams to propose sustainability improvements, many of which were successfully implemented under the “Sustainable Site” initiative. Established a measurable sustainability governance approach by actively tracking CO₂e metrics and institutionalizing transparent reporting through regular internal newsletters, thereby embedding sustainability into daily operational decision-making and transforming it from a conceptual objective into a visible, data-driven business practice.

Digital Transformation and Sustainability drive – Dr. Haridas ability to create an innovation-driven culture by multiple engagements of all stakeholders including customers is demonstrative by revenue growth of 131% in successful execution and recurring business of all digital projects that involved Cybersecurity, AI, etc. She ensured her team were equipped with required training and mandate cybersecurity certifications which resulted in customers opening doors for advanced cybersecurity projects including digital transformation initiatives at the world’s largest refining complex, which includes one of the largest integrated petrochemical manufacturing ecosystems globally.

These contributions were formally recognized with the “Global Disruptor Award,” presented by the Global President, honoring outstanding impact in driving innovation-led disruption across the organization in 2023.

I was invited as one of the panel member to judge the Sustainability Campaign July 2024 along with other global leaders. I have witnessed innovative culture, impacting business outcomes, catching up industry trends of Industry 4.0 and 5.0. She has invested significantly in team building and people development. She organized impactful offsite programs that successfully brought team members out of their comfort zones, enabling stronger collaboration, leadership awareness, and trust. These offsites played a crucial role in breaking silos and strengthening team cohesion, where I participated and witnessed her leadership vision and abilities in June 2023 with her and her team.

Under her leadership, the India team received multiple awards for business and operational excellence, recognizing sustained performance, disciplined execution and continuous improvement. The NSS -Net Satisfaction Index being right testimonial which increased by 45% year on year from 2023, 2024 during my tenure of Dr. Haridas reporting to me. These achievements reflect her ability to translate strategic intent into defined measurable outcomes while fostering a culture of accountability, excellence and pride across the Organization.

She pioneered a digital transformation–driven engineering optimization framework that enhanced manufacturing efficiency by 25–30% through the design and deployment of real-time digital staging dashboards. This solution enabled all the cross-functional stakeholders to collaboratively plan, execute, and monitor operations with

significantly improved turnaround time and reduced process inefficiencies. The initiative was recognized as an innovative, first-of-its-kind implementation within the organization and attracted interest from global engineering leadership for potential replication across international manufacturing sites, demonstrating its scalable enterprise-wide impact. This also serves to provide demand vs supply, business performance insights and capacity planning for each facility.

Recognition Within Schneider Electric

Within Schneider Electric, Dr. Haridas has received the BU Vice President Choice Award in April 2025 and the Global Disruptor Award in 2023. She has been singled out by global leadership in performance reviews and strategy presentations as a benchmark leader for the Industrial Automation business. Her leadership of the digital hackathon, which produced more than eighty implementable innovations across India, and the artificial intelligence-led sustainability innovation campaign, which produced fifty-five ideas with several deployed at customer sites, are cited internally as examples of how regional leadership can drive global product and service innovation. The recognition Dr. Haridas has received is, in the Schneider Electric internal context, reserved for leaders whose contributions are considered both individually outstanding and broadly multiplicative across the organization.

Forward Trajectory

Looking forward, Dr. Haridas's trajectory is one of compounding contributions. Her pattern across the past several years has not been merely to deliver against assigned objectives but to expand the operating frontier of the business unit she leads, by establishing capabilities (the operational technology and information technology Center of Excellence), assets (the new manufacturing facility), and methodologies (the artificial intelligence-led engineering transformation) that did not previously exist within the unit. Each addition has compounded the unit's growth, and each, in elements, has been transferred to other Schneider Electric geographies.

Based on this trajectory and on what I have observed of her leadership, my professional projection is that within the next three to five years Dr. Haridas will be operating at a global, rather than regional, scope, with influence on Schneider Electric's industrial automation strategy at the corporate level and on the broader industry's response to operational technology cybersecurity, artificial intelligence in industrial engineering, and the safe industrial deployment of artificial intelligence in critical-infrastructure environments. The succession-planning conversations I have participated in within Schneider Electric reflect this projection, and her continued contribution from a United States base would, in my view, be of direct strategic relevance to the United States industrial sector, which is itself in the early stages of confronting the same operational technology and information technology talent gap on a national scale.

The cost of substitution, in the counterfactual scenario where Dr. Haridas's continued contribution were not available, would not be the cost of replacing one leader. It would be the cost of replacing the

convergence of capabilities she alone holds in this business, which the labor market does not currently supply at depth.

Conclusion

Based on direct observation across the period from October 2022 -April 2024 directly and till date indirectly, my review of internal performance data, and my knowledge of Schneider Electric's global organization and the broader industrial automation labor market, I affirm the following without qualification.

Dr.Haridas performs in a critical role within Schneider Electric, a multinational corporation with a distinguished reputation in its field. Her role is not interchangeable, her contributions are not routine, the business and engineering outcomes she has produced would not have occurred under a less capable leader, and the labor market does not contain a deep substitution pool of candidates with her convergence of skills. She has functioned at a level of responsibility and impact that satisfies the standard set forth in 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(viii) for a critical role for an organization with a distinguished reputation.

I have spent more than twenty-five years in this industry, in operating roles, advisory roles, and leadership-development roles. I have written letters of this kind for a small number of professionals across that career. I stake my professional reputation, built across that career and reflected in the positions I have held at Schneider Electric, on the truthfulness of every observation in this letter. Should the Service require any clarification, additional documentation, or independent verification of any matter described here, I am available without limitation. The exhibit references in this letter point to actual Schneider Electric internal documents, and I will produce any of them on request.

I recommend Dr. Haridas's petition for classification as an alien of extraordinary ability under EB-1A without reservation.

Sincerely,



Jacco THOLENS

Regional Delivery Director – East Asia & Pacific

Industrial Automation

Schneider Electric, Australia

LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/jacco-tholens-9256b2/>

Email: Jacco.Tholens@se.com Direct line: +61 474913701

Office address: Notting Hill (Ferntree Place) VIC 3168, Australia.